

MP3 Players Go Wireless and Screenless

Wireless technology is not new but it is being used by the music system makers for the first time in India

■ SRABANI SEN

If you love listening to music but don't like to sit glued to the computer, tangled in wires, take a sigh of relief. Companies are rolling out music systems that are not only wireless but also screenless. Targeting the youth are the likes of Sony, Apple, Samsung, Transcend, Bose, Moser Baer and many more, making the competition indeed a fierce one. There are certainly more brand options and product features to choose from, to suit your needs and budget. When making your choice, establish whether you need an MP3 player for just listening to music or for storing photos and watching videos also.

Recently, Apple had re-designed its iPod Shuffle, which, unfortunately, did not stir up the youth. Taking the opportunity, Sony has come up with an innovative wireless and screenless MP3 system, taking the music system directly into the earphones. Sounds innovative but does it work well? In fact, it's interesting to see devices shrinking in size.

According to Yogesh Singhal, deputy general manager, R&D, Moser Baer, "Three factors are making devices miniature—light weight, small size and now wireless. Today's youth looks for innovative, hassle-free technology, and wireless technology suits them the most."

Moser Baer has one such music system with advance technology up its sleeves.

Wireless and screenless

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ers only recently. This technology can mainly be categorised into two segments—Wi-Fi and Bluetooth. But the latest MP3 technology has revolutionised the market—it has done away with both.

Most of the wireless MP3 players use the stereo Bluetooth technology but Sony has taken a leap further by building the MP3 player inside the headphones. It has no sound modification software, not even bass and treble controls. In fact, the only interesting software it has is Zappin, which has done away with the traditional display screen as well—yet another unique feature.

"Zappin scans through the music library by playing what the MP3 player thinks is the most recognisable clip of each song. The user can select short clips—about 4-15 seconds long—by pressing the jog dial while the music is playing," explains Tomonori Moroda, division head, home audio video, Sony India.

As the music player is built inside the earphones, user interface is a little innovative. By default, the MP3 player plays the music in alphanumeric order but the user can also play the music in shuffle mode by pressing



Sony Zappin

the shuffle control, which is located inside the right earphone. The bottom spine of the right earphone holds all the controls, which include volume rocker and jog dial. However, for this feature to work, the user needs to transfer the songs using content transfer software. This software analyses the music before playing it to the user and then determines the point in the track from where the Zappin will play. This information is then added to the information of the track which the Zappin reads.

"The Zappin function is being exclusively used by Sony," informs Moroda.

The SoundLink wireless music system by Bose Corporation is another piece of innovation. It is a one-piece portable speaker system that allows users to play music from their